Commercial balloon pilot

Edition Oct 2026

What the certificate lets you do

- **Fly for hire:** act as pilot in command carrying persons or property for compensation or hire (61.133(a)(1)).
- **Teach in balloons with no CFI certificate:** give flight and ground training toward a certificate or rating, endorse for the balloon certificate and for solo, and give the training and endorsements for a flight review or recency (61.133(a)(2)(ii); 61.3(d)(3)(i)).

Logging a lesson you give: endorse the student's logbook legibly with a description of the training, the length of the lesson, your signature, your certificate number, and "certificate expiration date or recent experience end date" (61.51(h)(2)). A commercial pilot certificate has no expiration date (61.19(c)). *Instructor's practice:* name, commercial LTA certificate number, signature, date and notes on the lesson.
Pilot's note (Brian Lynch): certificates don't expire, but endorsements do, so date every one. A student's solo endorsement, for one, must come from training given within the 90 days before the flight (61.87(n)).

The airborne-heater limit (61.133(b))

Checkride in	Certificate is limited to	Limit removed by
Hot air balloon	Balloon with airborne heater	Gas balloon experience + instructor endorsement
Gas balloon	Gas balloon	Hot air experience + instructor endorsement

Medical (61.23)

Flying for hire
2nd class
Or 1st. Valid to the end of the **12th month** after the exam month, at any age

Giving flight training
None
61.23(b)(5)

Private privileges, student, or a balloon checkride
None
61.23(b)(1), (4), (10)

The medical requirement for paid balloon flying took effect May 22, 2023.

Staying current

Flight review	Since the start of the **24th calendar month** before this one: at least 1 h of flight and 1 h of ground training, including Part 91. A passed practical test counts (61.56).
Passengers	**3 takeoffs and 3 landings** in a balloon within the preceding **90 days**, as sole manipulator (61.57(a)).
Passengers at night	The same, to a full stop, between 1 h after sunset and 1 h before sunrise (61.57(b)).

Carry and show

Pilot certificate, photo ID and, when the flight needs one, your medical, on you or readily accessible. Show them on request to the FAA, the NTSB, the TSA or any law enforcement officer (61.3). Report a new permanent mailing address in writing within **30 days** (61.60).

To earn it: age 18; at least a private pilot certificate; 35 h as a pilot, including 20 h and 10 flights in balloons, 2 flights as PIC and 10 h of instruction (10+ flights) with two 1-h test-prep flights in the 2 calendar months before the test month, 2 solo flights and a controlled ascent to 3,000 ft above the launch site (61.123(a), (h); 61.129(h)).

Sources: 14 CFR 61.3, 14 CFR 61.19(c), 14 CFR 61.23, 14 CFR 61.51(h), 14 CFR 61.56, 14 CFR 61.57, 14 CFR 61.60, 14 CFR 61.87(n), 14 CFR 61.123, 14 CFR 61.129(h), 14 CFR 61.133, Final rule 87 FR 71218 (Nov. 22, 2022), FR Doc. 2022-25288. Original card, not an FAA document. Study aid, not for navigation.